

How to prepare for an interview. Actually prepare.

The structured framework serious candidates use — before every interview. STAR stories, trap questions answered honestly, pre-interview research, and what to do in the room.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

Five things that matter most

- Know your ten career stories cold before you enter the room. Practice them out loud — not in your head.
- The STAR format (Situation, Task, Action, Result) is how interviewers score answers. Structure yours that way.
- Research is what separates candidates who get offers from those who don't. Company About page is not research.
- Know your compensation floor before the first call. The moment you're asked, it's too late to calculate it.
- Prepare three questions that demonstrate you've thought about the role from the inside. Generic questions hurt you.

The candidates who lose at the interview stage almost always lose on preparation, not on substance. The experience was there. The stories weren't ready.

This guide is a pre-interview checklist. Use it before every substantive interview.

STEP 1 — BEFORE THE WEEK OF THE INTERVIEW

Your ten stories

Every interview question is ultimately asking you to tell a story from your career. The candidates who have ten clear, specific stories — practiced out loud — can answer any question the interviewer asks. The ones who haven't done this preparation reach for examples in real time and find vague ones.

The STAR structure

For every story: **Situation** (context, briefly), **Task** (what you were responsible for), **Action** (specifically what you did — not "we"), **Result** (measurable outcome). Two minutes maximum. The result must be specific: "increased pipeline by 40%" not "significantly improved results."

Ten stories that cover everything

- A time you built something from scratch
- A time you had to fix something that was broken
- A time you led through a difficult situation or conflict
- Your biggest professional failure — and what you did about it
- A time you had to influence without authority
- A time you made a decision with incomplete information
- A time you disagreed with your manager and what you did
- Your single biggest accomplishment with numbers to back it
- A time you had to change direction mid-project
- A time you developed someone on your team

STEP 2 — THE TRAP QUESTIONS

The questions candidates consistently get wrong

"Tell me about yourself."

Not your life story. 90 seconds: where you started, what you've built, what you're best at, what you're looking for. End with why this role. Practice until it sounds natural, not recited.

"What's your greatest weakness?"

Not false humility ("I work too hard"). Not a fatal flaw. A genuine area you've identified and are actively working on — with a specific example of what you're doing about it. Shows self-awareness, which is what the question is actually testing.

"What are your salary expectations?"

Know your number before the first call. Give a range: "\$175K–\$195K base, depending on the full package." If pressed for exact: "My target is \$185K in base." If the range is below yours: "That's a bit below where I'm targeting — is there flexibility, or should we discuss whether this is a fit?" Do not dodge indefinitely — it reads as evasive after three attempts.

"Why are you leaving?"

Three sentences. Brief on what happened, genuine on what you learned or what changed, forward-focused on what you're looking for. Do not criticize your last employer. Do not over-explain. Say it once and move on.

"Where do you see yourself in five years?"

Honest and aligned. "In five years, I want to be doing [growth version of this role or natural next step]. This role seems like the right place to build toward that because [specific reason about the company or team]." Shows ambition without threatening them.

STEP 3 — THE DAY BEFORE

Research that actually matters

- Read the company's most recent earnings call, press release, or funding announcement
- Know their key products or services, their main competitors, and their stated strategic priorities
- Look up the hiring manager on LinkedIn — recent posts, career history, shared connections
- Read Glassdoor reviews from the last 12 months (not older) — note patterns, not individual reviews
- Know: what problem does this role solve for the company right now?
- Prepare three questions that show you've thought about the role from the inside. "What does success look like in the first 90 days?" is good. "What does the company do?" is not.

The question most people skip: "What happened to the last person in this role?" The answer tells you more about the role, the manager, and the culture than any job description.